

Memo

To: Dr. Derek G. Ross, Dr. Stewart Whittemore, and Dr. Susan Youngblood

From: V. Jasey Herrington

Re: Culinary Chronicles Meta-Analysis

Date: January 17th, 2026

Audience and Purpose

The *Culinary Chronicles* assignment served as the final project for my semester in ENGL 7000: Technical Editing. Its purpose as an academic assignment was to build an editing project from conception to publication. There was a dual audience for this collaborative cultural cookbook: outside contributors and our instructor, Dr. Ross. Our contributors, recruited through a CFP and word of mouth, needed the guidance of our editorial team in order to submit recipes that followed our style guide. Our readers and instructor expected a text that was accessible, usable, and followed best practices for editing. In the end, these expectations meant that *Culinary Chronicles* did not only present a collection of personal and cultural recipes, but modeled effective technical editing practices by prioritizing clarity, consistency, and rhetorical awareness.

For this project, I served as lead editor. This role required me to work on my skills in editorial oversight, collaborative editing, and patience. In this role, I was responsible for guiding the project from proposal to product, developing and maintaining the style guide, coordinating with peers, and ensuring consistency across contributions where possible. This position sharpened my ability to make principled editorial decisions, mediate differing perspectives within the group, and maintain a cohesive vision for the publication while allowing for flexibility.

Goals and Editing Process

The project goals guided both the editing process and the framework we followed to create and edit the cookbook. One of our primary goals was to develop a style guide that reduced ambiguity for contributors who had varying levels of writing experience. Rather than functioning strictly as a prescriptive document, this guide supported consistency, and improved efficiency across the editing process. This also helped prioritize clarity and accessibility in the final publication through standardized formatting and consistent recipe elements.

Our editing process unfolded in multiple stages, thanks to the structure of the course. Early in the semester, we focused on defining the rhetorical situation by identifying audience needs, assignment expectations, and publication constraints, drawing on principles from Cunningham that texts are shaped by their context (Cunningham et al., 2021). As submissions were collected, our team coordinated copyediting tasks that addressed clarity and consistency at a close-editing level, while also updating the style guide when patterns emerged identifying areas of confusion. Collaboration was essential to this project, since editing on this scale required negotiation, compromise, and an awareness on my part of differing perspectives and skill sets. At times, our group did not collaborate very well, due in part to my own inexperience as a lead editor. This learning experience has shaped my editing and leadership style in more ways than one.

Theories

Several theoretical frameworks informed my approach to this publication and its editing process. As mentioned, rhetorical situation theory informed our initial decisions on audience and purpose. Scholarship on style guides as ethical and rhetorical tools came from Adhya (2015) and Clem and Cheek (2022) and worked respectively to shape our emphasis on usability and consistency. Finally, theories of collaborative editing and social negotiation (Amare & Manning, 2009) reinforced the idea of technical editing as relational and process-oriented practice.

Works Cited

Adhya, E. (2015). Key elements of an effective style guide in the new age. *Technical Communication*, 62(3), 183-192.

Amare, N., & Manning, A. (2009). Examining editor-author ethics: Real-world scenarios from interviews with three journal editors. *Journal of Technical Writing and Communication*, 39(3), 285–303.

Clem, S., & Cheek, R. (2022). Unjust revisions: A social justice framework for technical editing. *IEEE Transactions on Professional Communication*, 65(1), 135–150.

Cunningham, C., Malone, M., & Rothschild, J. (2020). *Technical editing: A guide to editing in the workplace*. Oxford Press.